First News

16 Mar 2026

Employing Intelligent investing, a disciplined, long-term approach to wealth creation based on fundamental analysis, risk management, and emotional control.

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Global, Regional Markets

Wall Street had the worst sell-off since the conflict began, with the S&P, Nasdaq , & Dow, all dropping 1.5%–1.7%. Brent Crude surged past $100 to $102.66, sparking fears that rising energy and fertilizer costs could push oil toward $120–$150 if the conflict persists.

An Iranian missile strike recently damaged five U.S. Air Force refueling planes at Prince Sultan Air Base in Saudi Arabia. While U.S. Central Command declined to comment, officials stated there were no fatalities and the tankers are currently being repaired.

Overnight, the US escalated the two-week Middle East conflict by striking military sites on Iran's key oil export hub, Kharg Island, for the first time. The attack on this critical facility threatens to intensify the war, cause significant oil supply disruptions in the region

The Pentagon is moving the 31st Marine Expeditionary Unit (MEU) and the amphibious assault ship USS Tripoli to the Middle East as of March 14, 2026 31st Marine Expeditionary Unit (MEU), currently based in Okinawa, Japan. Approximately 2,200 to 2,500 Marines and sailors.

$100 Plus Crude Price Keeps Global Stocks Under Pressure

Brent crude oil prices have surged above $100/bbl for the first time since 2022, settling at $103.24 on Friday. Strait of Hormuz Blockade: Traffic through the strait, which typically handles 20% of global oil, has plummeted, with many tankers forced to reroute around Africa.

Overseas Fund Flow 3/13/26

- **Bought Equities** Indonesia $59.2 million
- **Sold Equities** Taiwan $2.42 billion South Korea $2.06 billion India $643.1 m Thailand $75.3 m Malaysia $35.2 m Vietnam $8.65 m Philippines $7.62 m

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The MSCI EM Currency Index slipped 0.5%. Emerging Market Stocks and currencies fell for a second straight week as the Middle East conflict hit risk appetite and pushed oil back above $100, raising fresh global inflation concerns.

Beijing-based Moonshot AI is reportedly seeking up to $1B in new funding at a $18B valuation to advance its Kimi chatbot. The startup's valuation has increased fourfold in three months, highlighting a major effort to compete in the global AI market

Hong Kong authorities are actively collaborating with airlines to expand flight capacity and solidify the city's position as a global transfer hub, aiming to capitalize on significant travel disruptions caused by the ongoing war in Iran.

South Korea and its global partners are proactively strengthening their energy independence, set to spark a vibrant revitalization of its world-class nuclear energy ecosystem. By prioritizing sustainable, home-grown power, reducing reliance on imported fuels.

The Japanese Yen (JPY) weakened past 159.45 per dollar on March 13, 2026, its lowest level since July 2024. This decline is primarily driven by a widening interest rate gap, safe-haven demand for the US Dollar (USD), and Japan's vulnerability to surging energy

DA MARKET SECURITIES

Asia-Pacific

	3/13/2026	3/16/2026	%Chg
Dow Jones	46,677	46,558	-0.25%
S&P 500	6,672	6,632	-0.60%
NASDAQ	22,311	22,105	-0.92%
PCOMP	6,113.58	6,113.58	0.00%
NKY	54,452.96	53,819.61	-1.16%
SHCOMP	4129.1	4095.45	-0.81%
HSI	25,716.76	25,465.60	-0.98%
KOSPI	5583.25	5487.24	-1.72%
SENSEX	76,034.42	74,563.92	-1.93%
TWSE	33,582	33,400	-0.54%
ASX200	8629.04	8617.09	-0.14%
BURSAKLCI	1711.01	1698.85	-0.71%
JCI	7362.12	7137.21	-3.05%
STI	4855.33	4842.27	-0.27%
SET	950.12	936.5	-1.43%
VNINDEX	1709.61	1696.24	-0.78%

DA MARKET SECURITIES

Commodities - Metals & Agriculture

	3/13/2026	3/16/2026	%Chg
WTI Crude	92.82	98.71	6.35%
Brent Crude	91.98	103.14	12.13%
Gold (Comex)	5164	5061.7	-1.98%
Silver (Comex)	85.21	81.34	-4.54%
Platinum Spot	2161.78	2028.32	-6.17%
Copper (Comex)	589.1	575.7	-2.27%
Nickel	7.8986	7.7236	-2.22%
Nickel Ore Phl 1.5%	80	80	0.00%
Nickel Ore Phl 1.8%	94.5	94.5	0.00%
Coal	131.1	137.3	4.73%
Corn	460.25	467.25	1.52%
Wheat	594.75	613.75	3.19%
Cocoa	3429	3297	-3.85%
Sugar	14.25	14.37	0.84%

DA MARKET SECURITIES

Strategy

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Philippines

Philippine unemployment rate jumped to 5.8% in January 2026, up from 4.4% in December 2025. This spike represents approximately 2.96 million jobless Filipinos, an increase of roughly 700,000 from the previous month's 2.26 million.

USD/PHP 59.865 Philippine peso fell to a new historic record low, with the USD/PHP exchange rate breaching the 59.735 level.

The SEC is moving to end its nearly five-year moratorium on new online lending platforms (OLPs). On March 12, 2026, SEC released draft guidelines for public comment that would lift the freeze—originally imposed in November 2021—while introducing a stricter "pay-to-scale"

- Proposed circular proposes new minimum paid-up capital requirements for financing, lending companies based on the number of online lending platforms they operate 30m pesos for financing firms with one online lending platform, 60m pesos for two OLPs 100m pesos for max of 10 OLPs
- Use of personal data for debt collection, borrower harassment, reputational pressure, or disclosure of a borrower’s indebtedness to third parties is strictly prohibited

Philippines is bracing for a potential 16% surge in electricity rates starting April 2026, primarily driven by skyrocketing global fuel costs following the outbreak of the US-Israel-Iran war.

Baguio City records its coldest temperature this 2025-2026 Amihan season at 9.0°C early Saturday morning, March 14, according to DOST PAGASA. The strong Amihan surge currently affecting the entire country may start weakening from Sunday.

DA MARKET SECURITIES

Philippines

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6058 -54.64 pts., -0.89%

Range 6,066.84 - 6,151.56

Breadth 68 (+) 108 (-) 79 (unch)

Block Php9.04B **Volume** 887M **Value** Php13.91B

Share buyback MRSGI AGI SMPH OPM MEG SM FRUITS

52wk H: ion opm
52wk L: medic ubp vlc

Overbought – pcor
Oversold – bpi vlc gtcap ssi

Active	Value
ICT	1180
SM	279
BPI	244
JFC	242
MBT	222
EMI	221
SCC	220
BDO	191
PLUS	154

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DA MARKET SECURITIES

Foreign Trade

NFB(S)	$61.385mn
Total FB Feb	$26.793mn
YTD NFB	$252.61mn

FB	2,650,303,203.11
FS	6,313,763,841.32
NFB(S)	3,663,460,638.21
TOTAL	8,964,067,044.43

Foreign Funds Bought
BDO JGS STI PSE GLOBA MWC URC EW APEX ACEN MONDE PGOLD JFC WEB PX CEB AC AP SCC

Foreign Funds Sold
ICT SM ALI TEL MBT PLUS SM BPI CBC CNPF SMPH AGI MYNLD LTG SGP PNB RCR GLO GTCAP AREIT EMI

Smartwatch
PCOR AP MWC SCC EMI DMC MER JGS ACEN

10yr Bond	3/13/20...	3/16/2...	%Chg
PHL	6.099	6.613	8.43%
US	4.187	4.269	1.96%

Currency Pair	3/13/2...	3/16/2...	%Chg
USD-JPY	157.71	159.73	0.64%
USD-PHP	58.916	59.748	0.06%
USD-CNY	6.8695	6.9037	0.24%
EUR-USD	1.1639	1.1417	-0.35%

NEWS, ANALYSIS , INVESTING INSIGHT

URC 68.50 - 1.58%

- **FY25 net profits missed estimates FY25 Operating income P16 billio, estimate P16.77 billion**
- URC eported a net income of ₱11.6B (down 9%) and core profit of ₱11.0B (down 4%), due to lower FX gains, high coffee costs.
- Nissin Foods Holdings is increasing its ownership in Nissin-Universal Robina Corp. (NURC) by acquiring an additional 21% stake.
- This transaction elevates its total voting rights to 70%, shifting the JV from a shared interest to a majority-controlled subsidiary

AC 523.0 -2.24%

- **FY25 Net income ₱61.4B, +46% Yoy Even without one-offs, net income +7% to ₱48.3B, robust banking BPI 101.5& property ALI 19.04 The 46% surge was primarily driven by: Revaluation gains from Mynt (GCash).**
- ALI selling its stake in Alabang Commercial Center.

ENERGY / COAL

- **DOE of the Philippines to Bid Out 18 Coal Blocks In 3 Areas**
- The Department of Energy (DOE) launched the 2026 Philippine Conventional Energy Contracting Program Pre-Determined Areas Bid Round for Coal on February 27, 2026. The auction encompasses a total of 18 coal blocks across three locations, covering 18,000 hectares:

MER 605.00 +0.83%
SCC 30.00 +4.71%

- **SCC Potential Partner: Meralco PowerGen Corp (MGEN), the generation arm of Meralco, has expressed interest in a joint bid with Semirara for the upcoming auction.**
- Shares of Semirara up 7.33% on March 13, 2026, driven by reports of a potential partnership with Manila Electric Co. (Meralco) to bid for a coal operating contract Trading volume reached over 130%
- MER aims to secure fuel supply for its thermal facilities through vertical integration.

NEWS, ANALYSIS , INVESTING INSIGHT

SCC 30.00 +4.71%

- **DOE Opens Bidding for 18 Coal Blocks, Including Semirara Island**
- The DOE on 27 February 2026 launched a competitive auction for 18 coal blocks across three sites, headlined by Semirara Island — currently operated by Consunji-led Semirara Mining and Power Corp. (SMPC) under COC No. 5, a 50-year contract expiring July 2027.
- The three pre-determined areas cover a combined 18,000 hectares: Semirara Island, Caluya, Antique (10 blocks / 10,000 ha); Amulung and Iguig, Cagayan (3 blocks / 3,000 ha); and Benito Soliven, Naguilian, and Cauayan, Isabela (5 blocks / 5,000 ha).
- The three areas hold an estimated 207.5 million metric tons of combined reserves, with Semirara Island alone accounting for approximately 160 million metric tons and roughly 94% of domestic coal production.
- The auction follows a DOJ legal opinion that existing 50-year coal contracts — such as Semirara's — cannot be renewed and must instead be subjected to public bidding.
- SMPC disclosed to the PSE that it "is focused on the bidding process and continues to operate under its existing Coal Operating Contract, which remains valid." A Pre-Submission Conference is scheduled for 19 March 2026; the application deadline is 28 April 2026.

Analysis: This is the single most consequential near-term risk for SCC. The DOJ non-renewal opinion has effectively ended SMPC's longstanding assumption that COC No. 5 would roll over, and the DOE is proceeding accordingly — with the pre-bid conference falling on 19 March, three days from now. The Semirara blocks represent ~94% of Philippine domestic coal output; any transition uncertainty translates directly to production continuity risk and capex planning paralysis at SCC. SMPC remains the most capable bidder by operational history, mine infrastructure, and financial capacity — but the competitive process means pricing power shifts to the government, and contract terms (royalties, work commitments, environmental obligations) under a new COC could be materially more onerous than the legacy 50-year arrangement. Near-term, SCC will likely continue operating normally through the existing contract's July 2027 expiry. The outcome of the April 28 bid submission — specifically, whether SMPC wins its own blocks back, and on what terms — is now the dominant long-term valuation driver for SCC.

Recommendation: NEUTRAL / MONITOR SCC. Do not add ahead of bid outcome clarity. Watch the 19 March Pre-Submission Conference for emerging competitor interest and term structure signals. Downgrade to AVOID if a credible competing bidder with stronger balance sheet emerges for the Semirara blocks.

NEWS, ANALYSIS , INVESTING INSIGHT

FGEN 18.02 +2.27%

- **First Gen Boosts 2026 Capex to ₱41.7 Billion; EDC Eyes Indonesia Geothermal**
- First Gen (FGEN) has set its 2026 capex at ₱41.7 billion, up 24.5% from ₱33.5 billion in 2025, as it advances a 2,000-MW pumped storage hydropower (PSH) portfolio.
- FGEN is acquiring a 33% equity stake in Prime Infrastructure Capital's pumped storage portfolio for ₱61.875 billion, covering the 600-MW Wawa PSH (Rizal) and the 1,400-MW Ahunan/Pakil PSH (Laguna). Both projects carry COD targets of 2030.
- In a landmark transaction (13 March 2026), a syndicate of eight Philippine banks — BPI, BDO, CBC, LandBank, MBT, PNB, SECB, and UnionBank — provided ₱214.87 billion in green project financing for the Pakil and Wawa hydro projects. MUFG served as green loan coordinator, with ₱58.6 billion in additional dual-currency equity standby letters of credit from MUFG, Mizuho, and SMBC. Total package: ₱273.47 billion.
- EPC contractors: Power China (civil works), Toshiba (Wawa electromechanical), Andritz Hydro (Pakil electromechanical).
- EDC (FGEN's geothermal subsidiary) is targeting initial drilling in West Java, Indonesia in 2026 — the first well in a multi-province program with Sinar Mas Group's PT DSSR Daya Mas Sakti. Combined target capacity: ~440 MW across West Java, West Sumatra, Jambi, Central Sulawesi, and Flores.

Analysis: The ₱273.47B financing represents one of the largest green project loan packages in Philippine history, providing full funding visibility for FGEN's PSH ambitions. A 24.5% capex hike is aggressive but strategically sound — pumped storage is essential for grid stability as renewable penetration deepens. The EDC Indonesia initiative is a significant long-term growth avenue; Indonesia holds ~40% of global geothermal reserves. The Sinar Mas partnership mitigates permitting and regulatory risk. West Java drilling results will be a key 2026 catalyst. Positive for FGEN and EDC: financing risk is now largely de-risked; execution risk remains.

Recommendation: ACCUMULATE FGEN. Key catalyst: COD milestone updates and EDC drilling results (H2 2026).

NEWS, ANALYSIS , INVESTING INSIGHT

TEL 1,311.00 (-0.46%)

- **PLDT Deploys ERICA — First Agentic AI System in SE Asian Telco**
- PLDT has deployed ERICA (Enterprise Risk Intelligence Companion Agent), an AI-powered governance system developed with UiPath, claimed as the first agentic AI application in a Southeast Asian telecommunications company.
- ERICA is designed to identify, assess, and manage organisational risks with greater speed and consistency.

Analysis: ERICA is a governance/efficiency tool rather than a revenue driver. It signals PLDT's operational modernisation push amid competitive pressure and cost management challenges. Limited near-term earnings impact. Neutral to mildly positive for TEL sentiment.

Recommendation: NEUTRAL / MONITOR TEL. Watch Q1 cost rationalisation results.

GLO 1,610.00 0.00%

- **Globe Deploys 400+ Wireless Laser Links via Transcelestial Partnership**
- Globe Telecom has partnered with Transcelestial (a Kickstart Ventures portfolio company) to deploy more than 400 wireless laser links nationwide over the next three years, targeting last-mile and backhaul connectivity.
- The rollout follows successful deployments in Visayas and Mindanao (2024-2025). Globe is also exploring Transcelestial's long-range "Legolas" laser links capable of transmitting up to 15 km, pending 2026 tests.

Analysis: A strategically sound infrastructure play for an archipelago nation where fiber rollout is slow and costly across 7,000+ islands. Laser links offer fiber-class throughput without trenching, compressing deployment timelines and costs. The tie-up strengthens Globe's 5G backhaul competitive moat against PLDT-Smart. Mildly positive for GLO near-term; strategically positive medium-term.

Recommendation: ACCUMULATE GLO on weakness.

NEWS, ANALYSIS , INVESTING INSIGHT

AEV 30.50 -1.61%

- **Aboitiz InfraCapital Completes Laguindingan Airport Runway Upgrade**
- Aboitiz InfraCapital (AIC) has completed a major runway surface upgrade at Laguindingan International Airport — Mindanao's second-busiest — including repainting, rubber removal, and crack repairs.
- Beginning 2026, Laguindingan's capacity is expected to increase to 6.1 million passengers annually (from the current 3.9 million target).

Analysis: Steady execution on AIC's ₱12.75B concession. The runway rehab is a maintenance milestone, not a transformative event, but signals operational discipline. The capacity expansion to 6.1 million passengers creates long-term commercial aviation revenue upside. Combined with the Davao Light submarine cable progress and the TARI Estate JV formalisation (13 Mar), AEV's infrastructure earnings pipeline is strengthening across multiple fronts. Mildly positive.

Recommendation: ACCUMULATE AEV. Multiple mid-term catalysts: TARI Phase 2, Davao Light cable, airport volume ramp.

MER 605.00 +0.83%

- Meralco Reviews Fuel Mix as Middle East Volatility Hits Power Inputs
- Meralco said it will review its fuel mix amid Middle East-driven commodity volatility. Current supply composition: 60% natural gas, 20-25% coal. Potential impact on power rates as early as April 2026; March bills and overall supply remain unaffected.
- Higher input costs will push up generation charges — the dominant component of electricity bills — potentially complicating near-term consumer sentiment.
- Despite headwinds, Meralco awaits: (1) ERC approval of its ₱7.98B undercollection claim; (2) rate reset decision (expected June–July 2026); and (3) a ₱2.34/kWh tariff adjustment application to fund ₱247B capex for 2027–2030.

Analysis: Share price weakness is sentiment-driven, not fundamental. MER's regulated earnings base means it has limited direct margin exposure to fuel cost spikes — higher generation charges are ultimately passed through to consumers. The rate reset resolution (mid-2026) remains the key re-rating catalyst. Any sustained correction toward ₱580–590 levels would represent an attractive accumulation window for patient, income-oriented investors.

Recommendation: BUY on weakness. Analyst consensus target: ₱607. Key catalyst: ERC rate reset decision (June–July 2026).

NEWS, ANALYSIS , INVESTING INSIGHT

RLC 17.24 -0.12%

- **Robinsons Land FY2025 Attributable Net Income Up 9% to ₱13.47 Billion**
- FY2025 attributable net income: ₱13.47 billion (+9% YoY; core income +9% YoY).
- Total revenues: ₱48.52 billion (+13% YoY). Mall revenues: ₱19.67 billion (+10%); Residential: ₱10.53 billion (+71%); Logistics (RLX): ₱890 million.
- Total mall GLA: 1.7 million sqm. Capex: ₱18.87 billion.
- RCR market cap: ₱150.53 billion (RLC holds 60.51% stake). 2030 profit target: ₱25 billion.

Analysis: A solid year for RLC, with core growth +9% underpinning the headline. The 71% surge in residential revenues reflects strong reservation-to-completion conversion. The RLX logistics segment, though small, is a high-growth asset in a structurally expanding segment. With the 2030 target implying ~13% annual profit CAGR from 2025 levels, valuation remains reasonable.

Recommendations: ACCUMULATE RLC. Logistics and mall GLA expansion are medium-term earnings drivers.

PSE-INDEX STOCKS

PSEi

	3/13/2026	3/16/2026	%Chg
AC	535.00	523.00	-2.24%
ACEN	2.52	2.64	4.76%
AEV	31.00	30.50	-1.61%
ALI	19.14	18.94	-1.04%
AREIT	39.75	39.30	-1.13%
BDO	121.50	122.00	0.41%
BPI	102.00	100.00	-1.96%
CBC	68.50	68.20	-0.44%
CNPF	35.75	35.50	-0.70%
CNVRG	13.46	13.00	-3.42%
DMC	9.55	9.76	2.20%
EMI	14.82	15.58	5.13%
GLO	1610.00	1610.00	0.00%
GTCAP	579.00	563.00	-2.76%
ICT	695.00	685.00	-1.44%
JFC	199.00	190.00	-4.52%
JGS	25.20	25.40	

PSE-INDEX STOCKS

PSEi

	3/13/2026	3/16/2026	%Chg
LTG	14.06	14.20	1.00%
MBT	68.95	68.45	-0.73%
MER	600.00	605.00	0.83%
MONDE	5.94	5.99	0.84%
PGOLD	39.80	39.80	0.00%
PLUS	19.96	19.08	-4.41%
RCR	7.00	6.95	-0.71%
SCC	28.65	30.00	4.71%
SM	646.00	637.00	-1.39%
SMC	70.00	69.10	-1.29%
SMPH	19.76	19.64	-0.61%
TEL	1317.00	1311.00	-0.46%
URC	69.60	68.50	-1.58%